

A **courtier**, one of several celebrating with their ruler, sits on a wooden stool and raises a cup in honor of the great occasion.

A **court musician** plucks at a lyre, decorated with the bull's head that appears repeatedly on examples of this apparently popular Mesopotamian instrument.

Standard of Ur

This object, whose purpose is a mystery, was found in the royal tombs at Ur. With 20-in- (50-cm-) wide wooden panels inlaid with shell, red limestone, and lapis lazuli, it reveals much about Mesopotamian life. This panel may show war booty being brought to court.



Oxen, sheep, and donkeys are apparently being brought in procession to the banqueting court. Perhaps they are being presented as spoils of war.

Heavily laden people in the procession are shown stooping visibly under the weight of sacks filled to the brim with foodstuffs and other valuable merchandise.

Fine detail in this scene gives insight into the clothing of the time. This figure is seen in a fringed skirt, while others sport woolen fleeces.

(see pp.44–45), Ebla, and Mari. By the 24th century BCE, many southern lands were under one king: Lugalzagezi of Umma. Farther west, Akkad became the center of a dynasty begun by Sargon (see left), whose influence expanded to the Mediterranean and Anatolia, resulting in the Akkadian language being used for official documents and diplomacy for many centuries to come (see pp.62–63, 66–67, 78–79).

A place for everyone

Mesopotamian society had a hierarchy and a centralized structure headed by rulers who were all-powerful but, unlike Egypt's pharaohs, were rarely thought to be divine. Grand royal palaces appeared throughout the region in the Early Dynastic era. We know of the sophistication and wealth of these palace cultures from discoveries such as the lavish, finely wrought

artifacts found in tombs at Ur where either royalty or priestesses (or figures combining both roles) were buried.

As in Egypt, specialists were needed to support such a society and its administration—a “professional” layer of experts such as bureaucrats, scribes, and merchants. In this urbanized civilization, many city-dwellers lived in impressive town-houses of locally sourced mud brick, mud plaster, and wooden doors.

A large labor force was needed to cultivate the land and run the great irrigation and building projects. However, there was some social mobility.

Some laborers appear to have owned land or received rations linked to their work for central government.



Royal game

This game board of c. 2500 BCE, inlaid with shell and lapis lazuli, was found in a royal tomb in Ur. This game was popular right across the Middle East, Egypt, and India.

Rule and religion

In common with other civilizations of the time, politics and religion were intertwined. Rulers took a lead in directing religious matters, while priests and priestesses conversely took on “state” functions; some cities were ruled by priests. Each city had a massive central mud-brick temple (such as the famous Ziggurat at Ur, see p.73), which was the home-on-Earth of the city's god and where priests carried out rituals to win the god's favor. Keeping order was made easier by the people's belief that they must do the gods' bidding, to the extent that, when royalty died, palace staff entombed themselves with their king or queen. Around 74 bodies were found in one grave at Ur.

A world player

Poor in natural resources such as metal and stone, the Mesopotamians, like the Egyptians, were forced to forge wide-ranging trade (and so diplomatic) links

During the next millennium, a succession of cultures inherited the land between rivers.

AKKADIAN DECLINE

As the Akkadian empire faded, local leaders won regional power in Kish, Uruk, and Lagash. The rule of **Gudea of Lagash** saw his city's last thriving era. Irrigation systems were set up, temples rebuilt, and statues of Gudea were carved.



GUDEA OF LAGASH

THIRD DYNASTY OF UR

After the Akkadian era, the Third Dynasty of Ur (c. 2100–2000 BCE) fought off competing city-states to found a short-lived empire built on Akkadian achievements. The **kings of Ur** revived central rule to create a **Sumerian renaissance** harking back to the region's former glories.

OLD ASSYRIAN ERA

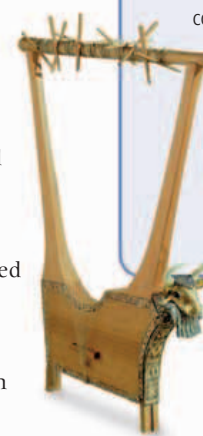
As the Ur dynasty faded, returning the south to rival city-states, the Assyrian city-state of Assur (c. 2000–1800 BCE) **80–81** >> emerged as the center of a vast trade network in the north.

OLD BABYLONIAN ERA

Since c. 1900 BCE, the city of **Babylon**, north of Sumer, had been emerging as a dominant power. The Old Babylonian era (c. 1894–1595 BCE) saw the rule of **Hammurabi** (c. 1792–1750 BCE) and his famous **law code**, a rich source of information about life in the Babylonian state.

MITTANI AND BEYOND

The Hurrian people of **Mittani 78–79** >> dominated the north (c. 1600–1350 BCE), until control passed to the **Hittites 78–79** >> and the **Middle Assyrian kingdom 80–81** >>. In the south, the **Kassites 78–79** >> controlled middle-era **Babylonia** (c. 1400–1100 BCE). Around 1100 BCE, the Babylonian state collapsed along with other great Bronze Age powers **78–79** >>.



Precious lyre

Playing lyres seems to have been a part of court or temple life in Mesopotamia. A bull's or cow's head is a recurrent decoration.

over a region that included modern Iran, Afghanistan, the Persian Gulf, and the Indus Valley. This drove much of the progress and expansion of their culture and gave them a leading profile in world politics. Mesopotamia took the lead in many fields. Its art included exquisite jewelry,

musical instruments, and beautiful stone carving dating back to 4th-millennium Uruk. In science, their numerical system based on the number 60 dates back to the Sumerians of the 3rd millennium BCE. It lives on today in our division of a circle into 360 degrees and in our splitting of the hour and the minute into 60 smaller parts.